CSD WEBSITE REDESIGN

Creative Brief for Web Designer

Navigator of Possibility — Brand Direction & Design Handoff

01 — Project Overview

CSD (Center for Social Dynamics) is refreshing its brand and website to better reflect its core purpose: helping families realize a brighter future for themselves and their child with the support of a skilled and deeply human clinical navigator. This brief equips the designer with the strategic and aesthetic direction needed to develop initial concepts.

The new brand rests on two conceptual pillars that work in tension and harmony:

Navigator — We guide families. We are trusted, reliable, and expert. We reduce overwhelm and cultivate hope and confidence.

Possibility — We believe in every child's potential. We create brightness and belief, celebrate successes, and believe dreams, like therapy, like children are innately individualized and aspirational.

The visual language must carry both — the steadiness of a trusted guide AND the warmth and optimism of someone who genuinely believes in what's possible.

02 — Audience & Emotional Context

Primary audience: Parents and caregivers of children with developmental, communication, or learning differences — often arriving at CSD feeling uncertain, overwhelmed, or having been bounced between providers without a clear path forward.

Secondary audience: Referring professionals (pediatricians, health insurance employees, school counselors, early intervention coordinators).

Client Demographics — Critical Design Inputs

- 70% of clients are male — visual language should feel inclusive and age-appropriate for boys; avoid skewing feminine
- 75% are age 8 or older — this is not a preschool or early intervention service; nothing should read as babyish, cartoonish, or aimed at toddlers
- Gut-check: would an 11-year-old boy be embarrassed to be associated with this? If yes, pull back. The aesthetic should feel confident, forward-looking, and slightly aspirational
- Photography should reflect age range: older children and teens are appropriate alongside younger; show kids engaged in real activities, not posed and smiling at nothing
- Importantly, most web visitors are mothers to these boys (women ages 30-40 – young Millennials), so aesthetic should feel nurturing, protective (mama bears), while hopeful and empowering.

What families feel when they arrive:

- Anxious about what their child's diagnosis means for the future
- Exhausted from navigating fragmented systems and a multitude of options – unsure how to know which is best
- Looking for someone who "gets it" and can take some of the burden off

What we want them to feel when they leave the site:

- Relieved — there's a clear next step
- Seen — this place understands kids like mine
- Optimistic — things can be different from here
- Confident — these people know what they're doing

03 — Brand Voice & Personality

Think of the brand voice as a highly competent, warm friend who happens to be an expert. Not clinical. Not corporate. Not overly cheerful. Just: clear, human, and genuinely on your side.

We Are	We Are Not	Design Implication
Warm & human	Cold or clinical	Rounded forms, photography of real interactions, approachable typography
Expert & structured	Chaotic or vague	Clear hierarchy, confident use of space, purposeful color
Hopeful & forward-looking	Cautionary or heavy	Light backgrounds, upward movement, growth-oriented imagery
Individualized	Generic or mass-market	Specific language, avoid stock-photo parents looking generically happy

Weighting the two pillars:

Navigator and Possibility should both be present throughout the site, but they are not equal in emphasis. Possibility leads — it should be the dominant emotional register of the experience, the feeling a family carries away. Navigator is the undercurrent that makes Possibility credible. Think of it as warmth supported by structure, rather than structure decorated with warmth. A site that feels primarily organized and clinical, with hopeful touches added, gets the balance backwards. A site that feels genuinely aspirational and human, with clear evidence of expertise woven through, gets it right.

04 — Color Direction

The palette below is directional, not final. The designer should feel free to adjust values, weight, and proportions. The intent behind each color should be preserved even if the specific hue shifts.

Name / Role	Emotional Intent
Blue	Trust, expertise, stability — the authoritative backbone of the brand
Teal	Discovery, innovation, energy — the brand's most distinctive and forward-looking color; intentionally vivid
Green	Learning, flourishing, progress — signals positive outcomes and development
Coral/Peach	Warmth, human connection, heart — prevents the palette from reading as too corporate
Gold	Momentum, mastery, earned progress — adds warmth and a premium note; counterbalances coral toward a more gender-neutral palette

Palette Exploration Suggestion

We'd ideally like to see two weight variations of this palette in initial concepts:

- Light / airy — white-dominant, color used as accents. Closer to Headspace.
- Bold / confident — color used more liberally in hero sections and backgrounds. Closer to Duolingo.

We are not wedded to a specific direction and want to see the designer's instinct on which serves the audience better.

05 — Design Inspiration

These reference sites were selected because something about their design approach resonates with the direction we're going. The designer should identify and extract those specific qualities — not copy the overall aesthetic.

Site	What We're Drawing From
Keebler keebler.com	The scroll-driven entry into the Keebler tree is the clearest example we've encountered of a website whose navigation mechanic is the metaphor itself — you don't just read about the world, you move through it. This is exactly the ambition for the path framework on the CSD site: the act of scrolling should feel like traveling a journey, with content revealing itself as the family moves forward rather than sitting statically on the page. We're not borrowing the whimsy or the brand world — we're borrowing the principle that the UX gesture and the brand idea should be one and the same thing. For CSD, entering the site should feel like stepping onto a path, not opening a brochure.
Kinder kinder.com	The combination of warm photo-video with purposeful graphic motion. Animated elements accompany content as it enters — the overall effect is genuinely warm and emotionally inviting without tipping into chaos. Two specific things to replicate: first, the way graphic elements reinforce meaning rather than fill space — motion signals discovery, growth, or connection, not just visual interest. Second, the use of real children in real moments of engagement creates immediate emotional resonance that abstract illustration alone cannot.

	What to explicitly avoid from this reference: The more abstract doodle elements — floating shapes, disconnected scribbles — that function purely as decoration. These read as playful but carry no meaning, and for an older, predominantly male client base, they undercut credibility. Borrow the warmth and the purposeful motion; leave the abstract marks behind.
Headspace headspace.com	How a complex, personal service feels calm and approachable rather than clinical. Use of whitespace, rounded shapes, and a restrained palette that still feels warm. Breathing room is a design value.
KiwiCo kiwico.com	Child-centered content that feels genuinely joyful without being chaotic. Photography of real kids actually engaged and curious. How to make parents feel excited, not just reassured.
Duolingo duolingo.com	Confidence in a bold, unapologetic color palette. How gamified progress and small wins can be communicated visually. A sense of momentum and forward motion built into the layout.
Mightier mightier.com	Direct peer in the child developmental space. How to speak simultaneously to the parent's rational concerns AND their emotional hopes. Evidence-forward without being cold.

06 — Website Purpose & Primary User Journey

This is not a brochure site. The primary job of the website is to take a family from uncertainty to a scheduled intake appointment — ideally within a single visit.

Primary Conversion Goal

Book an intake / contact CSD to get started

Anticipated User Flow

- "Does this place serve kids like mine?" → Services & specialties overview
- "Are they actually good?" → Outcomes, credentials, family stories
- "How does this actually work?" → Process, what to expect, FAQ
- "What do I do next?" → Clear, low-friction call to action

Design Implication

Each section of the homepage should be designed to answer one of those questions and advance the visitor to the next. Avoid organizing the site around CSD's internal structure — organize it around the family's journey.

07 — Visual Direction: What We're Open To

The moodboard (attached separately) establishes *directional* imagery and conceptual metaphors. The designer has latitude here. Specific items below are guidelines, not mandates.

Signature Visual Technique: Art on Photography

The core visual idea we're committed to is layering some form of illustration or graphic art on top of real photography. The photograph is doing important strategic work — it signals that CSD's program operates in the real world, produces real outcomes, and fits into real family life. The art layer is doing something different: it lifts the image into possibility, imagination, and aspiration. Together they say *"this is real, and it can be more."*

We are open to the designer's interpretation of what the art layer looks like — pencil sketch, clean vector illustration, fluid painted strokes, or other treatments are all on the table. The constraints are intentional rather than stylistic:

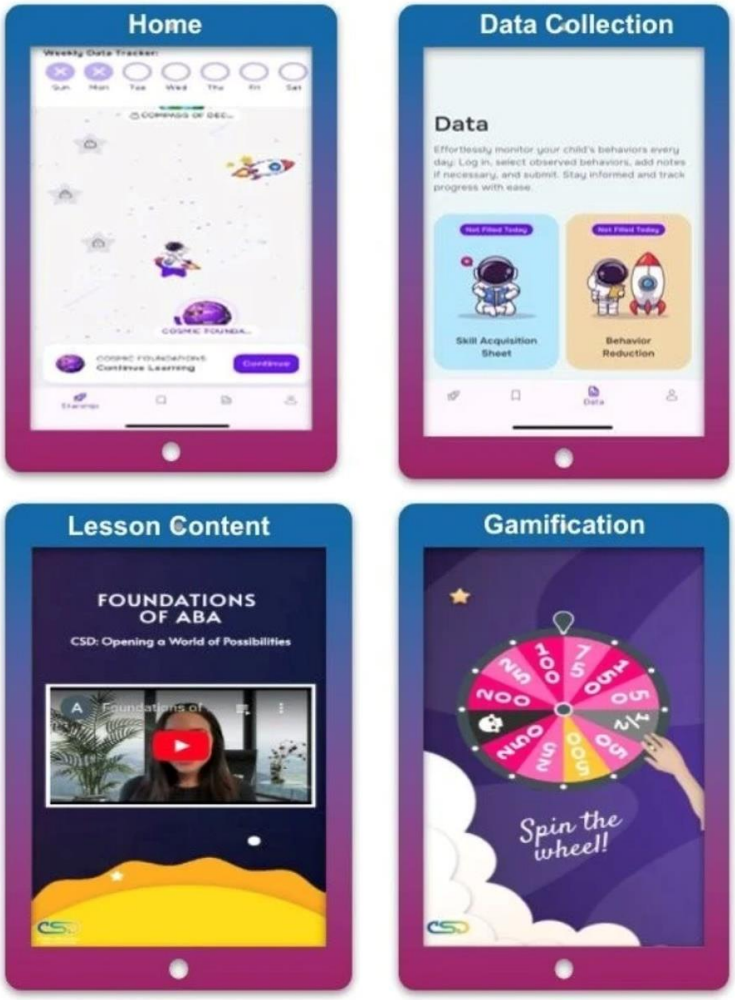
- The illustration layer should feel like it *belongs with* the photograph, not like it was dropped on top of it. Integration matters more than technique.
- It should carry meaning — navigational, growth-oriented, or forward-looking imagery resonates with the brand framework. Abstract decoration for its own sake does not.
- The treatment must read as mature and considered. Filled illustration is fine; the question is weight and style, not fill vs. line. Think editorial or studio art direction rather than children's app.
- When in doubt: would this feel at home on a thoughtful consumer brand aimed at adults who happen to have children? If yes, it's probably right.

Visual Consistency Across the CSD Experience

The style should be harmonious with the typical graphics utilized in virtual and VR sessions. Although we expect these teaching graphics to change/improve over time, we don’t want to create a web experience that is materially misaligned with what learners experience once they start with us.

Examples are included below:

Examples of our parent-facing app Starship are also included below (note the mobile frame is NOT part of the user experience):



We'd welcome the designer's instinct on technique as part of the concept presentation.

Photography Direction

- Real children in real contexts — therapy, focus, play, discovery, collaboration
- Avoid *generic* stock: no smiling families in white rooms, no posed "happy patient" shots (acknowledging we will be limited to stock photos for the time being)
- Include older children and teens — not just young children; the 8–15 range should feel represented
- Boys and male-presenting subjects should feature prominently given the 70% male client base
- Reasonable and likely appropriate to include images of moms, families, and/or clinicians alongside children or in below-the-fold sections.
- Candid and slightly imperfect beats polished and posed every time

Typography

- Approachable but not childlike — this is a professional service that happens to serve children
- Strong typographic hierarchy is important — families under stress need to be able to scan quickly
- Suggest exploring: a geometric sans-serif for headlines (confidence, clarity) + a humanist sans for body (warmth, readability)

Beyond hierarchy and readability, the combination of typeface and color palette should function as a standalone brand signal. The goal is for a headline set in the brand font, in the brand colors, to feel unmistakably like CSD — even without the support of photography or illustration. This matters practically: not every application of the brand will have room for art direction. Emails, slide decks, event signage, and partner collateral all need to carry the brand confidently on typography and color alone. The designer should select and pair typefaces with this in mind — the fonts themselves should have enough character to do meaningful work.

Layout & Motion

- Generous whitespace — the site should feel like an exhale, not an assault
- If motion is used, make it purposeful: progress, growth, forward movement — not decorative spinning
- Mobile-first is essential — many parents will arrive via phone in a moment of stress

08 — Deliverables Requested

For the initial concept round, we are requesting:

- 1-2 homepage concept directions (can be desktop wireframe + color comps, or high-fidelity mockups — designer's preference)
- Each concept should reflect a distinct interpretation of the Navigator of Possibility framework

We are not asking for full site design in this phase. The homepage concept will be used to align direction before extending to full production.

09 — What We Want to Avoid

- Anything that looks like a generic healthcare or therapy provider site
- Clip art, overly literal metaphors (e.g., literal lightbulbs for ideas)
- Blue-and-white medical aesthetic
- Typography that reads as "educational software from 2010"
- Overcrowded hero sections — lead with one clear message
- Passive, vague language like "Empowering families" — be specific about what that means

10 — Open Questions for Designer

We'd welcome the designer's perspective on these during the concept presentation:

- Should the Navigator and Possibility concepts be visually distinct sections of the site, or woven together throughout?
- Is there an opportunity for a signature visual element that anchors the brand system?
- Do we need original photography to achieve our desired experience, or is there a stock approach that could work at least temporarily?

Questions on this brief? Please reach out before starting concepts.